economic decision-making, though India was careful to ensure that the RIC dialogue did not adopt a confrontational posture vis-à-vis the West. However, this rebalancing ensured that India–Russia relations regained their salience. The importance of the Indian market for Russia's (now reconstructed) military-industrial complex, and the reciprocal Indian dependence on Russian weapons, contributed to this revival.

The Putin years

The accession to office of President Putin launched a qualitatively new phase in India–Russia relations. Putin came to office promising political stability, economic growth and restoration of sovereignty, military strength and national dignity, all of which had eroded during the political and economic decline of the 1990s. He sought to restore Russia's status as a great power within a multipolar world order, as spelt out in Russia's "foreign policy concept" of 2000.[2]

Putin indicated very early in his term that the "strategic partnership" with India was an integral part of this effort. In an interview to an Indian weekly prior to his first visit to India, Putin explained his perspectives on the bilateral relationship:

> the Russian leadership supports the theory of global strategic balance preservation. … We regard India as a key factor in international politics. … Russia and India are natural partners also due to their mutually complementary economic, scientific and technological potentials.[3]